opportunities for hanky-panky with strangers, though its actual incidence is uncertain.

Across India and in Khajuraho, big temples kept devadasis (‘female servants of god’). A Chandela queen is on record for offering devadasis to a Vishnu temple, though it’s not clear how common this was. ‘Married’ as young girls to specific gods, devadasis learnt the high arts of dancing, singing, music and theatre performed publicly at the temples. They pioneered and innovated many forms of art, such as the dance form Sadir (a precursor to Bharatanatyam). They didn’t need to honour caste boundaries, writes Thapar. ‘As women they could deny the centrality of procreation, not observe monogamy and have an independent income. Thus they opposed Manu’s rules regarding the subservience of women to fathers, husbands and sons.’[35]

Many devadasis however also served as cultured prostitutes to temple priests, officials, pilgrims, patrons and royals. Some inscriptions and texts from across India luridly remark on the sexual charms of devadasis. Could it be, as some scholars have argued, that there was once less public shame, stigma and exploitation associated with this profession than in the centuries closer to us? Many upper-class women were devadasis. If a king desired a married woman, he could work out a deal whereby she would sign up as a temporary devadasi, and he would then enjoy access to her without social disapproval. Some devadasis took long-term partners or said no to prostitution. Some of them even gained wealth and status, though many more surely dealt with sexual predators and lived lives of quiet desperation. Clearly, mere worship wasn’t top of mind for everyone associated with temples. Some of the surasundaris on Khajuraho’s temple walls are arguably devadasis, sometimes paired with ascetics and royal men and women.

At a macro level, then, Indian high society in the late first millennium CE, including in the Chandela realm, seems built by elite men for elite men. Its most remarkable feature was its immensely sex-positive culture. Women enjoyed a measure of sexual and intellectual freedom—at least enough to pursue whatever it took to be more alluring to elite men, and to use their sensual charms to get ahead in what was still predominantly a feudal patriarchy framed by caste rules.